The two armies, and their commanders, who clashed in the Himalayas in 1962 could not have been more different, and that is an important, and often overlooked, aspect of the war. It was a clash of civilizations, not only, or even primarily, a war for control of some remote mountaintops in the Himalayas or about where the border between India and China should be drawn.

Yaacov Y.I. Vertzberger, an Israeli scholar, argues that Nehru failed to understand the cultural and historical differences between India and China, and therefore grossly misjudged China's intentions. In Nehru's view, there was an objective, universally accepted, international legal system. If India only could back its case with maps and treaties, China would eventually recognize that India was legally in the right. China, on the other hand, has never paid any attention to international law, not at that time, as Vertzberger pointed out in his studies in the 1980s, and not much later, as we have seen in the South China Sea dispute. According to Vertzberger, Nehru did also not fully understand 'the basic differences between the process by which India had gained its independence and the one by which the Chinese were liberated from the Japanese and the domestic reactionary forces [the KMT]'.[16]

India had gained its freedom through civil disobedience campaigns, and thus with little bloodshed, which made it possible for the colonial power and the independence movement to part in what amounted to mutual friendship and respect. Mao Zedong's communists, on the other hand, had had an entirely different experience. According to Vertzberger, 'Thus, India could reject British colonialism as a general philosophy and yet adopt some of the trappings it had left behind, such as political culture, borders, and geostrategic thinking.'[17] Nehru had 'adopted British geo-strategic concepts, because for him there was a continuity between the past and present'.[18] There was no such concept of continuity on the Chinese side. Any agreement that had been signed with a foreign power before the 1949 Communist victory could be—and was—dismissed as 'an unequal treaty' that the new regime did not have to honour. Mao himself had made 'Abolish the Unequal Treaties!' one of the nine fundamental principles he outlined as early as 1925.[19]

While the Indian diplomats and academic researchers in the late 1950s and early 1960s were busy writing White Papers to prove that India's